



Smart TVs have been around for a while. But are they really worth it? Agent001 takes a look

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Thanks to CES, the term “Smart TV” is being heard quite often these days. Jayesh was lucky enough to actually play around with a couple of the smart TVs including LG’s 55-inch OLED TV supporting Google TV software, in Las Vegas. He was telling me about how some TVs such as the LG 55-incher and Lenovo Smart TV were based on a customised version of Android 4.0 aka Ice Cream Sandwich. Infact, the Lenovo TV even had a separate gaming pad to go with it.

Smart TV, to put it simply, is a TV system that lets you connect to the internet thanks to the circuitry within it which can accommodate network connectivity. It should also enable interaction with devices such as digital cameras, tablets, etc if they support the proprietary / DLNA standards such as AllShare for Samsung devices.

Last year, four major companies started selling smart TVs, namely Samsung, LG, Panasonic and Sony but that number has definitely increased this year and you’re bound to see a boom in this category across brands.

Samsung has smart TVs starting at around ₹48,000 for a 32-inch model (UA32D5900VR) going all the way to a whopping ₹4,00,000 for a 60-inch model (UA60D8000YR). There are many price points and sizes in between. A higher end model, Samsung UA46D5500 also offers 3D TV functionality. It’s an LED backlit LCD TV priced at ₹89,900 and it connects to the net via Samsung Apps. If you want a web browser and Skype as well, then you’ll have to go for an even higher end model.

The implementation of the Samsung Hub is quite decent, with the live TV going in a picture-in-picture mode while you browse other features. The Search All feature is impressive and it can search not only your TV and web, but also your online subscription services, connected devices via USB or HDMI or AllShare protocol.

The LG smart TV range has limited models and the maximum screen size available is 47 inches, and naturally its pricing is under a lakh but if you want to go for a Cinema 3D based smart TV, then be prepared to shell out in excess of a lakh. LG has a



clean layout and its main advantage is the motion sensing remote control. It kind of acts like an air mouse but the response wasn’t that great. It has tied up with Indian digital properties such as NDTV, Zapak, etc., which makes the content quite relevant to the Indian market.

Panasonic, on the other hand, has smart TVs with Plasma panels or LED backlit LCD panels. Its app ecosystem, Panasonic Viera Connect is neatly laid out based on categories. The Social TV feature allows you to chat in a sidebar while your TV screen gets compressed.

Sony’s Bravia line-up including series such as XBR-HX929, HX820, NX720 support Bravia Internet Video

with a built-in Wi-Fi module which can come handy while streaming. Bravia smart TVs have a very limited choice as far as apps are concerned.

So those were the four most prominent bands found at most of the malls I visited. Before getting a smart TV keep in mind the following four pointers:

- 1) Make sure you have a broadband connection else don’t think of getting a smart TV. You surely don’t want to just browse Twitter, Facebook, etc. You’ll want to watch streaming video content on your TV and make video calls on Skype and you don’t want buffering.
- 2) You might want to invest in a QWERTY remote as typing words using the standard remote control is a big pain. Sure you can get apps on your smart-phone for controlling the TV, but a QWERTY remote is a better option.
- 3) Do have a look at the apps offered and give more importance to those TVs offering India-specific content. You don’t want a TV with only apps such as Pandora, Netflix, Hulu etc, which won’t work in India, at least for now.
- 4) Don’t expect to get a demo of the online facilities at a mall. I tried out two malls and none of them had the provision to connect the TVs to the net.

With Google platform making an in-road into a lot of TVs – as Jayesh, who witnessed it all at CES (see “CES Special”, Page 12) explained – it makes sense to wait for the next gen smart TVs to enter the market. But if you really want a smart TV now, go ahead and get one keeping in mind the pointers above. Ideally, your new TV should have software upgrades to give you the latest apps, UIs and features. It’s a safe bet. ■